



LIFETIME ACHIEVEMENT

(Female)



M. D. Valsamma was walking through the ornate corridors of the Taj Mahal Palace in Mumbai, a few hours before she was set to receive the Lifetime Achievement award, from Jayen Mehta (MD, Amul) and former Indian cricket team captain Diana Edulji (**pic, below**), at the Sportstar Aces Awards. She asked the writer who else would be attending the event later in the day. The mention of P. T. Usha brought a sparkle to her eyes. Valsamma and Usha were part of a golden generation of women athletes from Kerala who helped raise India's profile at continental events. Their journey from Kerala's first sports hostel to the top step of the podium at the Asian Games inspired the next generation of track athletes in the state. The duo, along with statemate Shiny Abraham (now Shiny Wilson), formed three-quarters of the 4x400m relay team at the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics. Vandana Rao of Karnataka was the fourth member. The quartet made history by qualifying for the final, eventually finishing seventh.

"The four of us knew that we could run well. After the heats, the Americans were asking, 'Are there sports in India?' For us, there was nothing to lose," Valsamma said. "Puma was our sponsor for the Olympics. The spikes we wore were new. My toes were full of blisters and bleeding when I finished the race. Despite that, we ran a very good relay," she recalled. The same team also won gold at the 1986 Asian Games in Seoul, setting a Games record in the process.

Valsamma met Usha, now the IOA president, after the awards night. The duo also caught up with Shiny in the city the following day, as seen in a photo shared on X, bringing together once again the three pioneering sprinters who taught Kerala to dream.

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